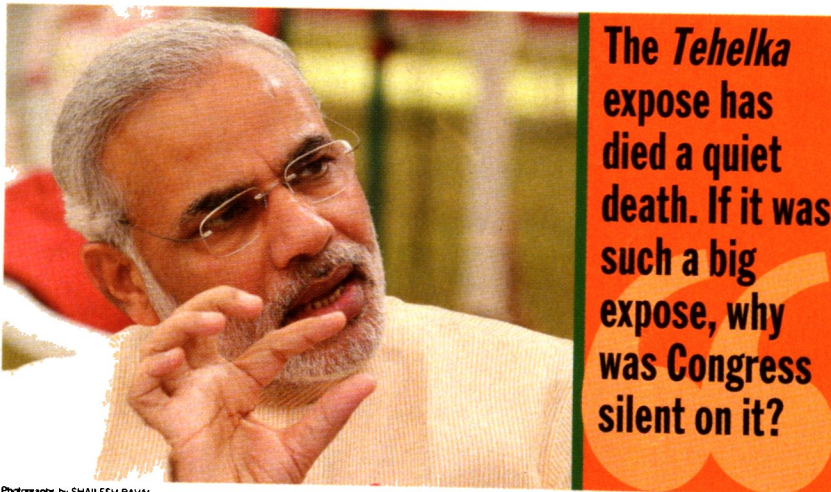


"Why doesn't UPA Government arrest me?"

Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi, 57, remains an enigma as he gets ready to face his second electoral battle. If the Tehelka expose early this month provided grist to those who have always pointed to the involvement of his Government in the 2002 riots, the developmental record he has set and the new administrative systems he has evolved have won him accolades from even his trenchest critics. He took time off from his hectic election campaign to speak on a range of issues to Associate Editor UDAY MAHURKAR. Excerpts:



Photographs by SHAILESH RAVAL

Q. Modi the developmental icon, Modi the Hindutva icon, Modi the autocrat. Which one of these is the real Narendra Modi?

A. Icon is not the right word for me. I am an ordinary BJP worker. Icons are Veer Savarkar, Bhagat Singh, Sardar Patel and Mahatma Gandhi. We only have to take inspiration from these great figures in our quest for greater good of the country.

Q. The 2002 polls were a trial by fire for you. But in the backdrop of the challenges this time, there appears to be a greater trial by fire.

A. In a democracy, only politicians have to give their account every five years and no other set of people in the

society. And elections are always a stern test. People have to evaluate politicians in this test with the sternest instruments. I have kept national interest supreme while appearing for this test. I am confident that people will repose confidence in me in greater degree than last time.

Q. What is the spirit behind BJP's poll theme "Jeetega Gujarat"?

A. Like the elections in Gujarat after the Emergency, in this election too it is the people who will set the poll agenda. And their poll agenda is fast development of the state. Whichever

party is seen to be furthering this, will get the votes. And, therefore, my mantra is "Jeetega Gujarat".

Q. The Congress is confident of winning the polls. Sonia Gandhi has been drawing huge crowds in the state while Rahul Gandhi will also join her soon. How will you contend this onslaught?

A. This is an electoral battlefield. Let Rahu-Ketu come and test their strength. The verdict will be out on the final day as to what impact they had on the people.

Q. You have accused Sonia of using the Government to spread Christianity by getting the Cross embossed on the new Rs 2 coin. Isn't it a wild charge?

A. I haven't accused anybody. I have simply said that before 2005, the coin used to sport the sign of Ashok Stambh and India's map. But after the Sonia-backed government took over, the map has been replaced by the Cross. It is for the UPA Government to explain why this has happened and at whose behest. My question is also for the pseudo-secularists. Had the sign been that of Lord Ganesh or Lord Ram, there would have been a big hue and cry. Why are they silent now?

Q. In 2002, there was a Hindutva wave and the Sangh Parivar was united. This time there is no Hindutva wave and the Parivar is divided. How will you win?

A. There is a difference between 2002 and now. Then the people had not yet tested me. The BJP was weak, having lost badly the state civic elections. In fact, BJP's graph of popularity was at its lowest ebb. The people voted for us on an emotional issue and we won. But this time they have tested me on the touchstone of performance, integrity and vision. I am better placed this time.

Q. What about the Tehelka expose on the 2002 Gujarat riots in which many perpetrators of the violence, who said they had your support, have been caught napping on the camera?

A. I am surprised that within 15 hours of the expose, none was talking about it and it had died a quiet death. If it was such a big expose, why was Congress silent on it? If powerful evidence of my involvement had indeed emerged then why does the UPA Government not arrest me?

Q. Many believe that your style of functioning is individualistic and goes against the RSS style of collective decision-making. That's why VHP and the Bharatiya Kisan Sangh have turned against you.

A. That's wrong and a creation of the media. I have been reared in RSS and in organisation activity where a